

Anxiety disorders

Anxiety disorders are a group of mental illnesses characterized by strong feelings of threat and fear, including panic attacks and an inaccurate appraisal of danger. Although there are many types of anxiety disorders, they usually share similar symptoms.

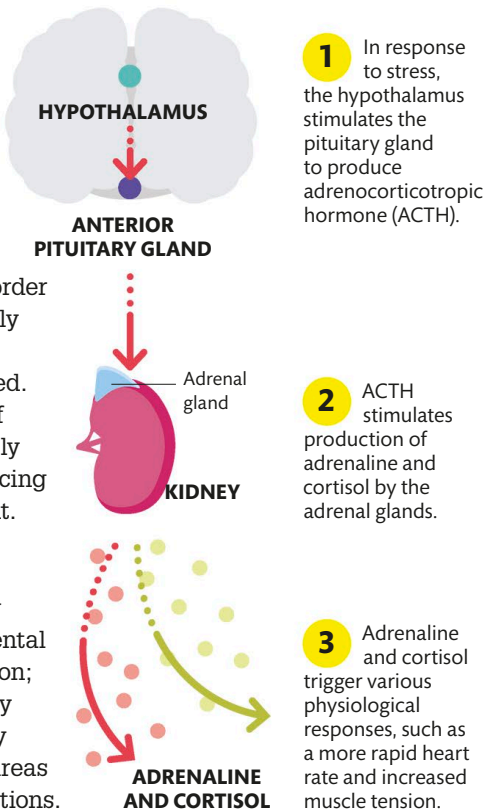
Common anxiety disorders include generalized anxiety disorder (GAD), social anxiety disorder, panic disorder, and post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). As well as feelings of fear, physical symptoms are brought on by excessive levels of stress hormones such as cortisol and adrenaline. Symptoms include trembling; sleep problems; cold, sweaty, numb, or tingling hands or feet; shortness of breath; heart palpitations; nausea; and dizziness.

Those with GAD are prone to feelings of intense worry, while panic disorder arises from an extreme bodily response to stress.

People with social anxiety disorder are worried, have an excessively negative self-image, and feel continually observed and judged. PTSD sufferers have feelings of being threatened and constantly on edge, triggered by experiencing or witnessing a traumatic event.

Contributing factors

Many factors influence anxiety disorders, including environmental stress and genetic predisposition; if disorders run in families, they may also be learned. Some may be linked to changes in brain areas that control fear and other emotions.



COMMON PHOBIAS	
PHOBIA	DESCRIPTION
Arachnophobia	Fear of spiders
Aviophobia	Fear of flying
Claustrophobia	Fear of enclosed spaces
Coulrophobia	Fear of clowns
Mysophobia	Fear of contamination by germs
Necrophobia	Fear of death or dead things
Nosophobia	Fear of developing a specific disease
Trypanophobia	Fear of injections or medical needles

Phobias

An overwhelming, debilitating fear of an object, place, situation, feeling, or animal is known as a phobia. Phobias provoke extreme reactions and involve an unrealistic, intense sense of danger.

A phobia is a type of anxiety disorder characterized by an excessive reaction to a specific trigger. In some cases, just thinking about the threat can make a person feel anxious, a condition known as anticipatory anxiety. Symptoms include dizziness, nausea or vomiting, sweating, palpitations, breathlessness, and trembling.

Phobias can generally be divided into two main types: specific or simple phobias; and complex phobias. Specific phobias center

around a particular object, animal, situation, or activity. Examples include acrophobia (fear of heights) and hemophobia (fear of blood). Common animal triggers for phobias are snakes (ophidiophobia) and spiders (arachnophobia). Simple phobias often begin during childhood or adolescence but tend to decrease in severity over time.

Complex phobias, however, are more disabling. These include social phobia or social anxiety disorder—a fear of social situations.